

TAMBARAM

Chromepet » Pallavaram » Tambaram West » Rajakilpakkam » Mannivakkam » Guindy » Keelkattalai » Nanganallur » Guduvanchery » Hasthinapuram » Pammal » Tambaram East

Medavakkam » Srinivasa Nagar » Kathipara Junction » Kovilambakkam » Sadasivam Nagar » Potheri » Selaiyur » Sembakkam » St.Thomas Mount » Madipakkam » Urappakkam » Paranur



99 AND COUNTING

A salute to auction house Murray & Co, pen seller Gem & Co and timeless rose milk sensation Kalathi Shop for their endurance and uniqueness **P4&5**



JUDGE A PURCHASE BY ITS COVER

From sharing unused bags to refusing unnecessary covers, these businesses in Chennai are finding ways to make packaging lighter, smarter and more responsible **P6**



The lack of a median opening on a section of Pallavaram-Thoraipakkam 200-Foot Radial Road forces commuters to run to board buses at Pallavaram Periya Eri bund bus stop

T.S. ATUL SWAMINATHAN

MTC buses plying on Pallavaram - Thoraipakkam 200-Foot Radial Road have a new excuse for not stopping at a bus stop on this stretch. And this one seems to be genuine, going by the images.

Commuters have decried the State Highways Department's move to put dividers due to which buses do not enter the bay to stop at the designated point. This is evident at the lake bund bus stop. Because of the cement blocks placed to demarcate the main road and the service lane, buses stop on the carriageway, forcing commuters to run from the shelters.

As the area around the bus stop is not bitumen-topped, commuters risk running on the uneven surface. A better idea for putting this bus stop to good use would be creating a small opening so that buses enter the lane

and stop at the bus stop, thus serving like a bay.

V. Sumathi Velan, a commuter, says, "Commuters have to wait in the open on a path with stones, raising the risk of falling when they run. Commuters have to cross over the road dividers and board the buses.

The State Highways Department should have provided a passageway between the dividers for commuters to board buses and drivers to navigate and exit."

R. Ilamathi, a commuter, says, "When the buses halt, the two-wheeler riders try to navigate, posing a risk to commuters. Youngsters and men can run and board the buses. Imagine the plight of women and senior citizens. On the carriageway, commuters stand along the vehicles. Metropolitan Transport Corporation should earmark a halting point area to prevent commuters from running before and after buses due to vehicular parking."

MTC buses have a reason to not stop here



The wide service road at Pallavaram Periya Eri bund bus stop where buses cannot enter.
PHOTOS: T.S. ATUL SWAMINATHAN

PLAN YOUR WEEK

Loan camp on July 18 in Perumbakkam

The Nesamani Nagar Residents' Welfare Association in Perumbakkam, in co-ordination with Tamil Nadu Grama Bank, Perumbakkam, is organising a mega retail loan camp on July 18, from 10 a.m., at BTD Apartments, Sri Varadapuram Main Road (Near Selli Amman Kovil), Perumbakkam. Vehicle loan, home loan, mortgage related queries can be clarified.

For details, call 83000 77258 and 91764 53025.

Plays at Chromepet academy



Chromepet Cultural Academy (CCA) will stage two plays, one on July 12 and the other on July 15.

'Varadhu Kutty-Paritchaikku Neramachu-2' is written by G. Radhakrishnan and directed by Y Gee Mahendra (the dramatist who is also enacting in the play) will begin at 6.45 p.m. on July 12.

On July 15, 'Vandhe Matharam Yenbom' by S. Sruthi will be staged at 6.30 p.m.

The play will chronicle India's relentless struggle for independence, viewed through the lens of legendary regional and national icons. The play will weave together the valour, sacrifices, and ultimate triumphs of India's greatest freedom fighters. The academy is located on Indira Gandhi Cross Street, off Radha Nagar Main Road, Radha Nagar.

For details, call G. Nagarajan, the academy's secretary, at 9444690174.

Expedite remaining work on Tambaram Eastern Bypass

R V BASKARAN

Work on completion of Tambaram Eastern bypass road is moving at a snail's pace.

On the Perungalathur side, after the relocation of TANGEDCO office and transformers, the widening of the stretch between GST Road and Sadanandapuram appears to be progressing slowly.

There is no progress beyond Sadanandapuram, where the forest area abuts the stretch for 1.5 kilometres.

Motorists have started driving on the stretch between Dr. Ambedkar Nagar and New Perungalathur for easy access to GST Road at New Perungalathur from Camp Road.

On the other end of this stretch, beyond Dr. Ambedkar Nagar, the



flyover work across the Rajakilpakkam Lake is yet to start.

R V Baskaran is a resident of Selaiyur

Widening of Tambaram Eastern Bypass towards Perungalathur, between GST Road and Sadanandapuram. PHOTO: SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT



You can be our volunteer writer

Dear readers, you can be our volunteer-writer by writing to us about issues and events in your neighbourhood. You should send the write-ups to downtownfeedback@thehindu.co.in. Letters must carry the contact number



Fix these two points on Medavakkam Main Road



G. RAMACHANDRAN

Two points on Medavakkam Main Road, within 50 meters of Madippakkam Koot Road and Paathala Vinayagar Temple, pose a risk to pedestrians and motorists.

One is along Vigneshwar Nagar Third Street, where motorists on the main road turn left to enter the locality.

There is a partially visible drainage pit. Many electrical wires are dangerously sticking out from this pit. There is also one electrical pole in the same pit.

Once, a two-wheeler rider fell near this point. Luckily, he did not fall on the wires or into the pit. He was able to get up with the help of others. However, he lost his purse, which fell into the drain.

The second is at the turning point between More



Super Market and the temple, marking the entrance to Vigneshwar Nagar First Street.

There seems to be a pit at the turn, covered by an iron sheet. The edges can bruise road users' feet. The sheet should be removed and the pit covered by concrete slabs.

Pedestrians and two-wheeler riders access the point in large numbers. The authorities concerned should set it right before anything untoward happens.

G. Ramachandran is a resident of Nanganallur

Road in Puzhuthivakkam battered

LAKSHMANA KUMAR A

Hindu Colony Second Main Road in Puzhuthivakkam is in a poor condition and needs repairs. The carriageway is marked by potholes, stones and an uneven surface, making it

difficult and unsafe for road users.

During rainy days, the situation becomes even worse as the potholes fill with water, making it difficult to identify the potholes and increasing the risk of accidents.



'Pedestrians at risk in Chromepet'

V. SANTHANAM

It has been more than four years since Tambaram City Municipal Corporation was formed, encompassing Chromepet, Pallavaram, Pammal and Anakaputhur regions.

The civic body's duty is to ensure that interior streets and lanes are not encroached upon and provide a safe and smooth passageway for pedestrians and motorists.

But the civic body has not removed any encroachments. On Station Border Road, the civic body has constructed a space to accommodate commercial establishments, encroaching upon the road; the Madras Institute of

Technology management allotted their area for road formation.

If the Corporation removes a few shops, there will be space for road users to reach Chromepet railway station and Station Border Road.

Also, on CLC Works' Road, Radha Nagar Main Road, GST Road Service Lane, and Rajendra Prasad Road, the same situation prevails: pedestrians are forced to walk on the carriageway.

The civic body should remove the encroachments on the roads and pavements and make them accessible for road users.

V. Santhanam is a senior social activist, and a resident of Chromepet



Two-wheelers parked on GST Road Service Lane in Chromepet.

The chaos at New Perungalathur crossing

T.S. ATUL SWAMINATHAN

At New Perungalathur junction, ever since motorists from Gandhi Road - Kamarajar Salai were allowed to take a right turn towards Peerkankaranai, pedestrians are complaining. Earlier, poles were placed to check vehicular traffic. The poles were removed recently.

Taking advantage of the situation, motorists from Otteri and Irumbuliyur make U-turns and from Otteri enter Gandhi Road - Kamarajar Salai.

Both pedestrians and motorists are caught between a sea of vehicles and struggle to cross the road.

To avoid this, pedestrians and motorists from Gandhi



Road risk their safety to cross GST Road. Traffic police personnel remain mute spectators to the chaos and do not come to

the aid of pedestrians.

L. Chandralekha, a pedestrian says, "I am not against motorists from Kamarajar Nagar

taking a right turn towards Peerkankaranai. A separate signal has to be facilitated. Earlier, motorists had to take right turns at

Vandalur junction. Motorists from Otteri and Peerkankaranai can use the underpass connecting Old GST Road and GST Road. Pedestrians have to dodge the vehicles and run. Even the pedestrian crossing line is taken over by vehicles." Pedestrians complain that motorists violating the traffic rules at the crossing do not signal and drive rashly.

The traffic junction is the gateway to the city and sees an enormous amount of traffic. Yet no action has been taken. Adding to the chaos, even drivers handling heavy vehicles from Otteri, take a u-turn, when motorists negotiate. Heavy vehicle drivers from Gandhi Road take a free left turn, which is more dangerous.

CAMPUS BUZZ

TERI confers sustainability award on Mannivakkam school

Competing in a fray of 300 schools across the country, Shri Natesan Vidyasala has won the Runner-Up Sustainability Excellence Award



Shri Natesan Vidyasala at Mannivakkam has been awarded the Runner-Up Sustainability Excellence Award by The Energy and Resources Institute (TERI), New Delhi, in recognition of its consistent efforts towards environmental sustainability. The school was selected from among more than 300 schools across the country and received a citation along with a cash prize of ₹10,000.

According to a press release, the recognition comes after three

years of dedicated work by the students and teachers. As part of an ongoing project, students have been studying the presence of microplastics in ocean and lakes and regularly submitting their research findings. Alongside this, they have actively participated in beach clean-up drives, organised awareness programmes on reducing plastic usage, and taken part in the Green Olympiad to deepen their understanding of environmental issues.



A platform to debate on global contemporary issues

Casagrand International School in Perumbakkam hosted its first Casagrand Model United Nations (CMUN) 2026, bringing together over 200 student delegates from leading schools across Chennai. The conference culminated in a grand valedictory ceremony, where exceptional participants were honoured with awards for their outstanding performance in diplomacy, leadership, public speaking, negotiation, and critical thinking.

Delegates deliberated on some of the world's most pressing issues across multiple committees. Students from leading schools, representing over 30 countries engaged in an insightful discussion on global issues, proposing solutions centered on Global Cooperation, Sustainable Development and International Peace, said a release.

Designed as an immersive simulation of the United Nations, CMUN 2026 provided students

with a platform to debate contemporary global issues, negotiate resolutions, and collaborate with peers while developing essential 21st-century skills. Over the course of the conference, delegates represented nations across multiple committees, engaging in thoughtful discussions that encouraged analytical thinking, consensus-building, and global awareness.

The guest of honour for the day was quiz master Abhishek Bharathkumar.

A campus-based skilling initiative

Avtar Career Creators Limited (ACCL), in partnership with MOP Vaishnav College for Women, has launched a campus-based skilling initiative to equip women with industry insights, practical skills and career development opportunities.

In a communication, Saundarya Rajesh, managing director, Avtar Career Creators Limited, said they invite colleges to partner in building this movement, and corporates to join in co-skilling, mentoring and hiring from the talent pool."

Charging needs sharing



While an EV charging point for each parking lot at a gated community is a desirable ideal, practicality calls for shared infrastructure

LIFFY THOMAS

Data engineer Kiruba Joy's search for a reliable EV charging facility in a gated community remains elusive.

Three years ago, when the resident association at the 300-unit apartment community in Porur, where Kiruba owns a flat, refused to facilitate a separate connection for him to charge his electric car, he shifted to a rented accommodation in Kolathur.

Now a resident of Paniyur near Uthandi, for the last nine months Kiruba has been visiting various apartment communities in South Chennai to invest in a flat that comes with a separate charging infrastructure for every parking lot. The hunt has been frustrating.

"After the State Government brought a notification in October 2025 that buildings with more than 50 dwelling units should provide fast charging points, I took it up with my association but they refused citing a safety issue," says Kiruba.

At his current home, he has a 20 meter wire running from the second floor of his flat's AC point to the parking area. As there are only six homes and no other tenant with an EV vehicle, Kiruba got consent from the other residents.

A gazette notification dated October 31, 2025 by the Housing and Urban Development Department of Tamil Nadu issued amendments to the Tamil Nadu Combined Development and Building Rules, 2019. It asks residential communities to provide a charging point for electric vehicles at every car and two-wheeler parking space. In buildings where the number of dwelling units exceeds 50, car and two-wheeler parking space earmarked for visitors shall be provided with fast charging points.

Many apartment associations *The Hindu Downtown* spoke note they are physical and technical challenges in getting even a basic common charging infrastructure, let alone a separate charging point for every parking lot. While many apartment associations discourage individuals from connecting their vehicles to their own meter, some allow it at the individual's risk.

Christopher M.P., a resident of a 120-

unit apartment in Thiru-Vi-Ka Nagar, Perambur, has a wire running from the third floor of his flat to the parking area where his electric two-wheeler is parked.

"Currently we have 6 electric vehicles in our community and the association was considering putting up a common charging point, but the vendor came up with the condition that even outsiders should be allowed to use the facility, which was not accepted, so we continue with this arrangement," says Christopher.

Many users like Kiruba who have switched to EV to reduce the budget on their fuel bills feel having just one or two charging points does not serve the purpose.

"For instance, it takes eight hours to charge my car and if there are even half-a-dozen EV cars in the community so you need an ample number of charging points," says Kiruba. He adds, "Charging from my home is cheaper than doing so at a common point as the latter involves a commercial rate and a fee for the vendor and association. So I am now looking for a community that also offers solar so my electricity bill would reduce drastically."

CREDAI's stand

After the State Government notification, the Confederation of Real Estate Developers' Association of India - Chennai sent a letter to the Additional Chief Secretary, Housing and Urban Development Department in November 2025, stating that it is not possible to provide individual charging infrastructure even in their upcoming projects.

"The requirement of a one-to-one charger-to-parking ratio may be technically unnecessary, financially burdensome, and operationally impractical, especially in large residential developments," reads the letter signed by A. Mohamed Ali, president, CREDAI- Chennai.

The Confederation suggested that Tamil Nadu follow a progressive, scalable model that includes a minimum of three EV chargers for buildings with 10-75 parking slots; one charger per 25 parking slots thereafter; upgradation to one per 18 slots by 2030 and one per 15 slots by 2035; and mandatory trunking, ducting and electrical provisioning to double capacity when required.

99 and counting

Enduring gems

Even as Music Academy is on course to complete its hundredth year, three other enterprises, also born on Madras soil in 1927, are headed in the same direction. A salute to auction house Murray & Co, pen seller Gem & Co and timeless rose milk sensation Kalathi Shop for their endurance and uniqueness

LAKSHMY HARIKRISHNAN

There are four parts to longevity in business. One part is ingenuity, and the other three are just plain, old-fashioned, boring stick-to-itiveness. Those four parts working in perfect synchronicity, seller of pens, a whopping number of them fountain pens, Gem & Co has continued at the same address on NSC Bose Road in George Town for no less than 99 years. As it is poised to complete 100 years of existence in February 2027, there are no signs it could be running out of ink.

M. Pratap Kumar, representing the third-generation at the reins of Gem & Co after grandfather M.C. Cunnann and father M. Prabhat Kumar, has had greater need for those three parts because of the times in which he is holding those reins. Pratap is penning Gem & Co's brand story challenging the digital onslaught as seen by the writing pad being increasingly replaced by the keyboard.

And then there are the mundane hiccups, the gremlins that play a nasty trick on you when you do not even suspect their existence. Having seen 64 summers, Pratap has had a share of these niggles, finding some of those summers tough, and some winters too, the latter indicated by the shop's increased height.

"We had to increase the height of the shop because of the water coming in during every rain as a result of the road level going up over the decades, and we had to

pump out the water or manually push it out," explains Pratap.

The overarching challenge however comes from the digital takeover of writing and the pervasive disposable, throwaway culture particularly pronounced where stationery is concerned. In 1927, when his grandfather M.C. Cunnann and business partner S. Venkatarangam Chetty were seeking to shift the focus of their business from general trade to one focussed on an exclusive product line, and the lot fell on fountain pens and Gem & Co as its known today was born, no hazy clouds of doubt hung over the decision. The clouds would not drift in for many decades to follow. Back then selling fountain pens was a sensible choice as children often went through the grades with the same fountain pen.

"Now , this business is not feasible, but we are still running it because of the passion we have for fountain pens. It is running in my blood," Pratap observes, sheer pride in the trade overriding everyday realities. "The profit is less; customers have become less." Pratap has steered the family business since 1985 and the enthusiasm for designing and selling fountain pens, particularly hand-crafted artisanal pens has not flagged. True to what its name is associated with, the Gama line of fountain pens made and marketed by Gem & Co remains "undefeated". It is named after the legendary undefeated pehalwani wrestler Ghulam Hussain Baksh Bhat (1878-1960) who went by the ring name "The Great Gama".

"My grandfather was a patriot and a freedom fighter; he wanted the pen to be named after an Indian hero," Pratap observes. "My grandfather would have thought

the pen would be as strong as the wrestler."

Pratap reveals that "the making of plastic moulded pens are outsourced to manufacturers elsewhere in India such as Mumbai. The ebonite, hand-crafted pens are made by us." Though remaining steadfast to its ebonite craftsmanship, the company has embraced the changing times by introducing models, vibrant acrylic and transparent demonstrator fountain pens among them, likely to appeal to the younger generations. The store also repairs fountain pens, restoring what are treasured possessions to their keepers and cannot be valued in purely materialistic terms.

Who actually keeps Gem & Co up and writing its long story?

Certainly not those like this reporter who was briefly drawn to a fountain pen just to have an experience close to that of a Victorian writer hunched over an unwritten page, a dip pen in hand, a lit candle on the table, and perhaps, a dramatic rumble of thunder disturbing the quiet. The patrons of Gem & Co are not drawn to

fountain pens on account of a fleeting excitement; they have written the use of fountain pens into their everyday script.

"We are able to sustain the business because of the generation that has been buying from us for 40, 50 and 60 years. But the customer base is not restricted to them. A steadfast customer, who is 92

years old, continues to buy from us, now for his grandchildren. People from those generations pass on the interest to their children and grandchildren, who head to our shop to buy fountain pens.

A 'rose' keeps blooming

Kalathi Shop at North Mada Street in Mylapore shuns the glare of public attention. Text requests for newspaper interviews can go unanswered. Considerable ink about Kalathi shop has been spilt on newsprint; and the novelty of press coverage has long worn off. Food bloggers and vloggers have offered it their share of glorification; there are enough bytes about Kalathi out there to sustain a 24-hour nonstop programming schedule on television. On Google, Kalathi shop manages an impressive 4.3 against 4,193 Reviews.

So much attention being showered on a petty shop, its limited dimensions and address unchanged since its inception in 1927, for what? A drink it fills a small rectangular pet bottle with. Its rose milk has captured generations of taste buds. It sells other items including newspapers, but reels in visitors from far and wide for its rose milk, and has consolidated a set of loyal followers far beyond Mylapore's radius.

For the last 15 years since he discovered this shop, Suresh Kumar. V., a resident of Valasaravakkam, has headed to North Mada Street many a time just to savour the chilled drink.

Many try to recreate the taste at home buying rose milk essence from Kalathi. Siji S., a resident of Nungambakkam, says she has experimented with Kalathi's rose milk essence several times. While she has come close, she admits she has never been able to plicate the exact taste.

Pratap seeks to present a proper measure of fountain pens, one shorn of the romance that goes with them. They are "economical, eco-friendly and remarkably durable"; he however, believes their value lies beyond practicality.



Gem & Co at NSC Bose Road in George Town.

'Every transaction is special': Murray & co

Any popular music consumer who scours the decades for earworms would be familiar with the phrase "Hammer time", sung elegantly by M.C. Hammer in his "U Can't Touch This". In Madras and now Chennai, a different form of 'Hammer time' has been playing out since February 10, 1927 when Murray & Co saw the light. In the 99 years plus a few months of its existence, the auction house has not given that hammer a break except for a couple of times due to inescapable situations. What does the continuity mean to those at the helm of Murray & Co?

Hemant Srivatsa, partner, Murray & Co., responds: "We are very proud of it. We have conducted Sunday auctions almost without fail since our inception. There were a few weeks during our relocation when we had to pause, and of course, the pandemic was the longest period we could not hold auctions. Other than that, we have kept the tradition going."

Enterprises can dig their feet in, 'take over' a place by imprinting their character on it. And one cannot think of that place anymore without that enterprise popping up in the mind. And then enterprises take over people's mind space,

Since February 10, 1927, the hammer at this auction house has not had a break except for two seasons. The operational space has changed a few times, but its place in people's mind space has not



The team at Murray & Co

becoming a household name. Murray & Co has done both. After being identified with one space for a long time, a space behind the iconic LIC building on Mount Road, it has had to change addresses,

but its hold on the mind space of the city's residents has been unchanging and firm.

Hemant throws light on the addresses the auction house has had to its name.

"Our original auction room was located behind the LIC Building until 2012. We then briefly operated from Mandaveli before moving to our current premises at Gemini Towers, near the Gemini Flyover."

On how the business has evolved over the years, he observes: "We started with real estate auctions. From there, we expanded into retail auctions of household goods and furniture, followed by industrial auctions. There has always been a transition as the business adapted to changing times."

Hemant continues: "Within the retail space, the categories have changed significantly. We sell far more electronic items today than when I joined the business in 1992. The market has evolved, and so have the items."

Online auctions are becoming increasingly popular. Where does Murray & Co stand in cyberspace?

"Our industrial auctions are already completely online. Our retail auctions have not fully transitioned yet, though our online portal is currently being developed. Even after it is launched, we want to continue our physical auctions because they have a charm of their own that no technology can replace," says Hemant. And when prodded to name one transaction that has been hugely memorable for Murray & Co in the almost 100 years of its existence, Hemant refuses to take that route.

"Every single item is memorable. Every transaction is special, not just for us, but for the person who entrusted it to us and, hopefully, for the person who eventually bought it." Have grands plans been etched to celebrate the centenary when it arrives? "Yes, the plans are still in the works. Over the next few months, we will come up with concrete ideas to celebrate the centenary."

SHARON JESSICA MICHAEL

A statement about mindful choices

Packaging doubles as a brand statement. A clothing label at Karpagam Gardens in Adyar, Tula India has dispensed with the branding part and instead made packaging a statement about mindful choices.

"We will ask customers to bring their own bags. Most of our customers do, and we'll also educate them," says Sushmitha R.K, designer at Tula India.

The approach begins well before a garment reaches the store. Cotton is transported in airtight plastic sacks that are reused year after year, while woven fabric moves between production units in reusable sack bags instead of new packaging. "So the cycle keeps repeating. Instead of buying new plastic covers every time and discarding them, we keep reusing what we already have," she says.

Garments are displayed without individual plastic covers. Customers are encouraged to bring their own bags, but those who forget are offered newspaper bags made by autistic adults using recycled newspapers or reusable cloth bags stitched from leftover organic cotton fabric. "Whatever big pieces of fabric are left after production, we make our cloth bags from them," says Sushmitha, adding that the bags are often pieced together from two or three fabric scraps.

The leftover fabric also serves another purpose. Larger parcels are wrapped in these fabric pieces, while smaller consignments are sent in paper envelopes.

Interestingly, the cloth bags are not sold despite customer demand. "Many people want to buy those bags because they like them. But we tell them the bag is not for sale. There's no purpose in buying another bag just to own it when you already have many bags at home," she says.

The store also uses conversations and posters to encourage customers to rethink disposable packaging.

For more information on Tula's approach to reducing unnecessary packaging, contact 8056163560 / www.tula.org.in

The bag bank

A cardboard box outside the entrance of Kazhani Native Farms in Kottivakkam has become an unlikely solution to a common retail problem. Instead of selling new carry bags, the farm invites customers to drop off extra shopping bags for others to reuse.

For Gokulnath Natesan, founder of Kazhani Native Farms, the idea stemmed from a growing dependence on packaging as the farm expanded its range of products. "As the product range increased, the

Aesthetically designed boxes, glossy wraps and branded bags often shape the way we purchase. But behind the appeal lies a growing question: how much packaging do we really need? From sharing unused bags to refusing unnecessary covers, these businesses in Chennai are finding ways to make packaging lighter, smarter and more responsible

Judge a purchase by its cover



Environment-friendly packaging and containers at Tula and Restore.

usage of packaging materials also increased," he says. "We realised that while we were conscious about sustainability and waste management, in another way we were increasing the usage of plastics."

Walk-in customers are encouraged to bring their own bags and containers, particularly for loose produce. For products such as juices and oils, customers are asked to return the same containers for refills. "We will fill it again and give it to you. Until it is good, you can use it instead of throwing it away," says Gokulnath.

The cardboard box outside the store extends the same idea. Customers leave behind extra carry

bags they no longer need, allowing others who arrive without one to reuse them.

"Instead of charging them, we told them they can take the bag. Similarly, if you have excess bags at home, you do not need to throw them away or keep filling your shelves. Just leave them here," he says. While home deliveries still rely on plastic packaging where alternatives prove impractical, Gokulnath says the reuse initiative has significantly reduced the farm's purchase of new carry bags.

"It has reduced our bag purchasing costs and plastics, and it has become a good habit for people," he says. "As others started dropping off excess covers, they also began

bringing other waste."

The farm now serves as a drop-off point for vegetable and garden waste, dry waste, e-waste and old garments. "The transaction does not end with the purchase," says Gokulnath. "It goes back as a message, creates awareness and builds an eco-friendly environment together."

For more information, contact @kazhani.in / Instagram - [@kazhanifarms](https://www.instagram.com/kazhanifarms)

Take a discount in your own bag

For most shoppers, the bag is an afterthought – a necessity con-

sidered only after the purchase is complete. At Restore on East Coast Road, Kottivakkam, it is the starting point of the shopping experience, where customers are encouraged to carry their own bags and rethink the way they approach packaging. Restore functions as the sister concern of Organic Farmers Market (OFM), an initiative built around connecting farmers directly with consumers. While both operate independently, they share a network of farmers and a common vision of creating a more community-driven approach to consumption. Customers who walk in with their own bags or containers receive a 2% discount on groceries, a small gesture that encourages a larger change in the way people approach packaging.

According to Karthik R, General Manager, the idea is to make carrying reusable bags a natural part of the shopping routine. "We request customers

to bring their own bags and containers, especially for planned purchases like rice, grains and pulses," he says.

According to Karthik, although the discount is small, customers have responded positively to the initiative. Since nearly 70% of the revenue already goes back to farmers, the organisation cannot offer a larger discount.

However, he says the incentive has helped encourage more customers to adopt the practice. This practice has been part of Restore's approach for years. Plastic packaging has almost completely been eliminated from the store, with brown paper bags provided only when required. For products such as oils, customers are encouraged to bring their own containers, while glass bottles are available for those who need an alternative. But getting people to change a familiar habit has taken time. "In supermarkets, everything is packed and ready. People simply grab products and leave," says Karthik. "Asking customers to bring their own bags is a completely different paradigm."

He says the challenge is not the availability of alternatives, but the mindset around them. "People think minimal packaging is difficult or doesn't suit their lifestyle. But it's actually very easy," he says. "Customers tell us bringing their own containers simply becomes another item on their shopping checklist." There are, of course, practical hurdles. Paper bags can sometimes tear under heavier loads, requiring the store to constantly adapt its packaging methods. Yet, the focus remains unchanged.

For more information, contact @restore.org.in / Instagram - [@restoreorg](https://www.instagram.com/restoreorg)



Ensure restoration of Nanmangalam Lake

On July 6, volunteers of the Saving Nanmangalam Lake Team met M. Veerappan, Chengalpattu District Collector and urged him to take measures to save the waterbody.

Originally spread over 150 acres, today the lake has shrunk because of encroachments.

R. Sathya, a core volunteer, expressed apprehension over the drawing of water by water tankers through deep borewells.

“If the situation persists, the groundwater in the region might get depleted. Further, untreated sewage from residential colonies around the lake is let into the lake, contaminating the waterbody. Overflowing contaminated water from other lakes also drains into the lake. As a result, a good part of the lake is covered by water hyacinth, preventing rainwater from

being stored.”

A voluntary organisation that has restored waterbodies was entrusted with eco-restoration, de-weeding and protection of the lake. Only partial fencing has been completed. An official audit should be conducted to complete the work, volunteers pointed out.

Sewage inflow prevention

Volunteers want all sewage entry points blocked. A temporary modular sewage treatment plant installed until an Underground Drainage (UGD) system is functional.

Fencing infrastructure: Issue an immediate directive to complete the pending fencing along the vulnerable southern bank (Nanmangalam - Sembakkam Road) to block unauthorized access by commercial vehicles.

Eco - restoration and channel



R. Sathya of Saving Nanmangalam Lake Team, with M. Veerappan, Chengalpattu District Collector.
PHOTO : SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

Desilting and boundary demarcation: Execute deep desilting to remove toxic accumulated sludge from the lake bed, and mark the precise boundary of the remaining lake area.

In reply, the Collector assured that he is considering using CSR Funds to rejuvenate around four to five lakes and will also take steps to include the Nanmangalam lake.

P. Saravanan, MLA, Sholinganalur Assembly constituency, indicated that he will schedule a meeting with NGOs next week to explore the potential for Infosys funding to support the restoration of the Nanmangalam lake.

Text by : T.S. Atul Swaminathan

clearing: Launch immediate mechanical de-weeding to clear the water hyacinth canopy, and conduct an official survey to evict en-

croachments along the downstream channel towards Keezhkattalai Lake to ensure proper flood mitigation.



Handicraft expo at Egmore Museum campus

The Tamil Nadu Handicrafts Development Corporation Limited (Poompuhar) is having a handicraft exhibition till July 19 at Government Museum campus in Egmore.

Aimed to promote handicraft heritage, the event provides a common platform for artisans from various states to market their products

directly to the public, said a release.

From bronze icons to brass traditional lamps, Thanjavur paintings, art plates, papier mache dolls, bamboo crafts, wood carvings, stone sculptures, clay and terracotta products, cane furniture, jute products, fashion jewellery, incense and perfumery, there's a lot to choose from.

Purchasing traditional handcraft-

ed products from artisans will support the livelihoods of artisans and craft communities while preserving India's rich artistic and cultural heritage, the release added.

The expo was inaugurated on July 7 by P. Mathan Raja, Minister for Micro, Small and Medium Enterprises.

T. N. Venkatesh, Principal Secretary, Government of Tamil Nadu, Handlooms, Handicrafts, Textiles, and Khadi Department, and S. Amirtha Joshi, Managing Director, Tamil Nadu Handicrafts Development Corporation Limited (Poompuhar), participated.

'Road surface at Guindy bridge has developed bumps'

H. MOSES DONALD

Through this report, I wish to draw the attention of the authorities to the hazardous condition of the road surface on the Guindy bridge in Chennai.

The surface on the bridge has developed several uneven bumps and undulations, making it extremely dangerous for two-wheeler riders. Navi-

gating these irregular surfaces is particularly difficult for senior citizens and others who travel on motorcycles and scooters.

Riders are forced to slow down suddenly or swerve to avoid the bumps, increasing the risk of accidents, especially during peak traffic hours and in wet weather.

As the bridge carries heavy traffic every day, it is essential that the road sur-

face be inspected and restored to a smooth and safe condition without delay.

Timely maintenance would help prevent accidents and improve commuting safety for thousands of road users.

Are these bumps caused by poor workmanship, heavy traffic loads, settlement of the bridge deck, ongoing maintenance practices?

H.Moses Donald is a resident of Pazhavanthangal

Rath yatra from July 16

International Society for Krishna Consciousness's Jagannath rath yatra will be held in Anna Nagar, T. Nagar, Mugulivakkam and East Coast Road on July 16, 17 and 19.

The celebrations will include rath processions, 'Harinam Sankirtan', 'Kirtan', 'Arati', cultural programmes and prasadam distribution.

For details, call R. Subramanian at 98400 76024.

Tamizh Theatre Festival from July 14

Bharatiya Vidya Bhavan is conducting "Tamizh Theatre Festival 2026" consisting of four dramas from July 14 to July 17 at its main auditorium in Mylapore.

The inaugural event is scheduled for July 14 at 6

p.m. This year "Iyakkunar Sigaram K.Balachander Award-2026" (instituted by Kavithalayaa Sri Krishnan) will be presented to well-known drama artist Sachu on the inaugural day. The dramas will be staged every day at 6.45 p.m. On July 14: UAA pre-

sents Varadu Kutty-Parrichai Naramachu 2; July 15 Three presents Kaatrinely Varum Geetham; July 16, KNT presents Vee-ra; July 17, TV Varadhara-jan and team presents Sangeetha Mumoorthigal. The programmes are open to all.

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Green meets evergreen on college campus

The silver jubilee reunion of the 2001 batch of Women's Christian College offered an object lesson in sustainability, one that shut the door firmly on single-use plastics, use-and-throw culture and excess in celebration and opened the gates to composting of food waste, responsible consumption and green gifts

KANNAL ACHUTHAN

After the film 96, there is a pervasive trend of organising the silver jubilee reunion on a grand and memorable scale. 'Memorable' usually translates to adding extra layers to the celebration, sometimes making it extended to include a stop at a scenic location beyond the campus, say, a dinner at a resort. Rarely does 'memorable' mean paring the celebration to its bare minimum and make it meaningful, not just to the alumni but the wider world.

When they met for their 25th on their campus in Nungambakkam on July 10, the 2001 batch of Women's Christian College embraced the rarer version of "memorable",



having the event guided largely by two factors, simplicity and ecological sustainability.

Saranya Palanichami, a readily recognised name in sustainability circles, being part of this batch,

one expected plastics to be shown the door. But the scale of the zero-waste consciousness she ushered in was beyond what was imagined.

"We did not have plastic water bottles or cups. Instead, we used



▼ The batch; plants given to teachers and the 'enthu pataani' souvenir for alumnae; and cloth bag made with fabric bits. PHOTOS: SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT AND KANNAL ACHUTHAN

steel tumblers for water and juice. No single-use cutlery. No printed invitations," notes Saranya.

Food waste was taken for composting.

The alumnae got cloth bags made from fabric scrap from tailors and boutiques. These bits of cloth would have ended up in dumping grounds if not repurposed, she points out. Teachers, some of them now retired, received plants as mementos and winners of a fun quiz received gift vouchers.

Spotlight on SDG 3

It was a "celebration" of Sustainable Development Goals (SDGs) all the way. SDG 3, which is about health, was in bold relief, thanks to a panel discussion on navigating perimenopause. It made great sense as the alumnae are in their mid-forties.

Ardhra Ashokan, who travelled from the United States for the reunion, said that it was important for women to be able to reach out among their own network for support when going through this phase of life. "We need each other," she says, adding that the ex-

perts on the panel were drawn from the alumnae of WCC. Fitness and lifestyle coach Sheba Devaraj, clinical psychologist Debora Myrtle Anish of Stanley Medical College and Hospital and nutritionist-dietician Grace Gnana Priya discussed the importance of taking care of mind, body and soul. Sheba even did an onstage demo of the "inchworm workout", which requires no equipment and deploys one's own bodyweight for strength training.

Gravitas and light-heartedness went hand in hand. After Susan George and group offered wonderful choral singing, the "madcap moments" started rolling. Going retro, the dancers of the batch performed to 'Mambo No. 5', the chemists in the batch donned lab coats to take a group photo and teachers sportively stepped in for a jive.

Jubilee Daniel and Sobana Laxmi took people down memory lane with their quiz. And when they asked what was the name of the mangy dog that lived on campus in 1999, pat came the answer. Nobody had forgotten Henry, one of the few males on campus.

Changes in pattern of train services

The Chennai Division of the Southern Railway has enacted changes in the pattern of electric train services on July 12 to facilitate line and power blocks in Chennai Egmore - Villupuram section, between Chennai Beach and Tambaram railway station, from 10.30 a.m. to 15.30 p.m. for engineering works.

Full cancellation of electric trains

Train Numbers : 40329, Chennai Beach - Tambaram at 10:30 a.m., 40623, Chen-

nai Beach - Chengalpattu at 10:45 a.m., 40331, Chennai Beach - Tambaram at 11 a.m., 40333, Chennai Beach - Tambaram at 11.15 a.m., and 40335, Chennai Beach - Tambaram at 11:30 a.m.

Passenger special trains

Chengalpattu - Tambaram at 9.30 a.m., Kancheepuram - Tambaram at 9.30 a.m., and Tambaram - Chengalpattu at 11.45 a.m., 12.45 and 13.15 p.m.. will be operated.

Cancellation of trains

On July 13 and 15, the following trains will be cancelled. Train Numbers: 40531, Chennai Beach - Chengalpattu, at 11.28 a.m., 40533, at 12.02 p.m., 40535, at 12:30 p.m. and 40540, Chengalpattu - Chennai Beach at 13.35 p.m..

Passenger specials

Chennai Beach - Tambaram at 11.28 a.m., 12.02 p.m., 12.30 p.m.. and at 13.45 p.m.

For full details, log on to <https://x.com/DrMChennai>

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